

the basics of accelerated depreciation. We'd do almost anything to bypass the master's degree in business, a well-known first step toward making a fortune.

After graduation, those of us who didn't move to small towns or join the Peace Corps dedicated ourselves to handicrafts, obscure academic endeavors, low-paid arts jobs, or public-service careers. All along, we pitied our unfortunate acquaintances who'd wanted to get rich from the start and had proceeded directly to Wall Street. How unhappy and narrow these poor souls must have been, we thought. Those same poor souls are now the managing partners at Goldman, Sachs or Salomon Brothers, making millions of dollars a year, and no doubt just as friendly, charitable, courteous, and kind to their children as the rest of us who've just begun the struggle to get richer—having belatedly recognized the advantages of economics over the pre-Colombian politics we've already forgotten.

Convinced that motivation is the key to success, I forced myself to stay awake for several evenings in a row so I could watch the television programs on how to get rich. Most of these are shown after midnight and wasted on an audience that is half-asleep, which is too bad. Otherwise, we might be a much more prosperous country than we are today.

During these broadcasts, many nice-looking men and women step out of their Rolls Royces or hop from the cabins of their parked Lear jets to give testimonials to the advantages of wealth, after which they promise to reveal the proven ways of acquiring more of it. Most favor investing in real estate, where, to hear them tell it, you needn't put up any cash at all. One man described how he'd upgraded himself from short-order cook to millionaire in just a few months by purchasing distressed properties with his credit cards. Though of course he no longer lacked for money, he was selling a mail-order course to share his techniques as a public service.

Mr. E. J. Cossman, another TV millionaire, stood beside an American flag and told how he'd made a fortune selling metal spud guns and plastic ant farms. His idea was to get the rights to backyard inventions and to promote them with common-sense mar-